

NATIONS UNIES
BUREAU DU COORDONNATEUR
DES SECOURS EN CAS DE CATASTROPHE



UNITED NATIONS
OFFICE
OF THE DISASTER RELIEF CO-ORDINATOR

UNDRO

MEMORANDUM

A - TO: All UNDRO Staff

REF.:

DE - FROM: Faruk N. Berkol
Under-Secretary-General
Disaster Relief Co-ordinator

GENÈVE, 31 March 1978.

OBJET - SUBJECT: Office Rules for Correspondence

... The rules attached are promulgated for guidance in dealing with the correspondence of the Office. I expect them to be faithfully observed.

F. Berkol

OFFICE OF THE UNITED NATIONS DISASTER RELIEF CO-ORDINATOR

Rules for Correspondence

1. General guidance on United Nations practice for all forms of correspondence is given in the Correspondence Manual (ST/AI/237), which also shows examples of United Nations standard formats.
2. All correspondence must be clear and accurate in content, direct and dignified in style, correct in form, and attractive in appearance.

Responsibility for drafting correspondence

3. The principal responsibility for drafting all forms of outgoing communications and for their substance and factual accuracy rests with the individual officer charged with dealing with the matters in question. Should there be raised in incoming correspondence any subject which does not clearly fall within the sphere of responsibility of any one officer, the Co-ordinator, Director, or Director of the Relief Co-ordination, Preparedness and Prevention Division will charge an appropriate officer to deal with that subject.
4. If an incoming letter cannot be fully answered within five working days, an interim acknowledgement should be sent.

Clearance of outgoing correspondence

5. Drafting officers below the level of Chief of Section will obtain his clearance for the draft before it is sent for final typing, or for further clearance by the Director of the RCPP Division, the Director of the Co-ordinator.

Signing of correspondence in letter form

6. Letters addressed to Heads of State, Heads of Government, Permanent Representatives, Ministers of Foreign Affairs, heads of specialized agencies, and officials at the Under-Secretary-General and Assistant Secretary-General level and all letters concerned with major policy issues will be signed by the Co-ordinator whenever he is present in Geneva.
7. The Director will sign letters concerned with matters affecting more than one Division of UNDRO and letters on major administrative questions.
8. The Administrative Officer will sign all other letters, memoranda and forms connected with administrative, budgetary, financial and personnel questions. In his absence they will be signed by the Director.
9. The Director of the Relief Co-ordination, Preparedness and Prevention Division will sign letters concerned with matters for which his Division is responsible.

Procedure in the absence of the Co-ordinator

10. In the absence of the Co-ordinator, the Officer-in-Charge will sign correspondence under his own name and title. If necessary, letters dealt with in this way may refer to the Co-ordinator's absence on mission: the place of mission should not be specified.

Presentation of correspondence for signature

11. Correspondence for signature will be presented to the signing officer with all enclosures, all copies, and an addressed envelope attached. (This rule may be varied if the enclosures are bulky: in this event a tab marked "Enclosures to be attached before despatch" will be placed with the correspondence.)
12. When the Co-ordinator is to sign, the correspondence will be forwarded to him through the Director. The green copy will be placed on top, and initialled in pencil by the officer responsible for the letter. The relevant file will also be attached.

Cables and telex traffic

13. All cables and telexes will be signed in the Co-ordinator's name (adding "UNDRO GENEVA" for all traffic addressed other than to Headquarters) unless the Co-ordinator is absent from Geneva and
 - a) it is necessary for the recipient to know that the Co-ordinator is away, or
 - b) the message is addressed to an office of a UN or other agency at which the Co-ordinator is present, or
 - c) the message is of a personal nature to an addressee mentioned in paragraph 6 above.

On these occasions the message will be signed "(Name) Officer-in-Charge UNDRO".

14. Authority to authorise cables and telexes is given to named officers. Clearance of cables and telexes will be given according to their content, following the guide in paragraphs 5 - 9 above.
15. No cable or telex is ever to be sent in the first person (e.g. "I approve...") without the prior clearance of the officer whose name appears at the end of the message.

General

16. Whenever for any reason a letter is to be signed by an officer below the levels indicated in paragraphs 6 - 9, it is desirable that the substantive portion of the text be drafted in the third person, e.g. "It is thought that the General Assembly, in deciding the mandate of this Office..."
17. When drafting replies to letters addressed to the Co-ordinator, but for signature by another officer, it is normal to refer to "the Co-ordinator" unless the sense requires the use of his full title, i.e. "the United Nations Disaster Relief Co-ordinator".
18. It is the Co-ordinator's usual, although not invariable, custom to insert in manuscript the salutation and valediction on letters he is to sign. The words "Dear..." and "Yours sincerely" or their equivalents are therefore not to be typed when the letter is prepared for signature. They may be inserted after signature, if required. The signature itself will be followed by the typed words

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or the French equivalent.

19. References to UNDRO itself in letters signed by the Co-ordinator are to be made by using the words "my Office" or "this Office" (capital "O") or, if appropriate to the context "the Office of the United Nations Disaster Relief Co-ordinator". These words are the official, and only, interpretation of the acronym "UNDRO", and no other interpretation is ever to be used in any document emanating from, or circulated within, the Office.
20. English is the language to be used for internal memoranda, etc. 